Friends of the Ochils

Scottish charity registration number SC 022034

ANNUAL REVIEW & FINANCIAL REPORT 2008-09

CHAIR'S REPORT 2008-09

The year has continued to see the Friends of the Ochils involved in considerable activity in a number of areas.

Recent leaks and press reports indicate that a decision on the Beauly to Denny powerline is imminent and Nicki Baker and colleagues in Stirling Before Pylons continue to campaign vigorously for the key section around Stirling to be built underground. The damage to the Ochils landscape and the surrounding area would be too horrific to contemplate if giant pylons were to be built along the proposed route through the Ochils and beyond.

Recent key activities have involved the lobbying of Keith Brown, the local MSP, through the postcard campaign; a visit to Brussels to secure the support of all Scottish MEPs; and a visit to North Yorkshire to evaluate the terrain through which powerlines have been undergrounded. A huge debt of gratitude is to be extended to Nicki, Peter Pearson and many others for sustaining such a vigorous campaign.

The wish of the developer to bring the grid connection from the Burnfoot Hill windfarm down the scarp face of the Ochils to Alva continues to give serious concerns and meetings have been held with Clackmannanshire Council officials to discuss the issue. The Council has advised the developer that a planning application will be required and it is anticipated that such an application will be submitted. We will vigorously oppose any such route as, one would hope, will the Council. To allow such a development would scar the 'face' of the Ochils as well as seriously compromising the aims of the Ochils Landscape Partnership.

Meanwhile the Friends of the Ochils have objected to the proposed wind farm north-west of Saline on landscape grounds. With turbines 400 feet high it would be highly visible from the Ochils and there would be a serious cumulative impact with windfarms already built or approved in the Ochils.

The damage to Paradise Pool on the Wharry Burn is an ongoing issue and will continue to be pursued with the ultimate objective of restoring the pool to its former state. We are also keeping a watching brief on the problems of unacceptable wild camping in Dunning Glen. Following a clean up in early in 2009 during which over 60 bags of rubbish were collected by volunteers brought together by a local fishing

association, notices have been erected requesting that camping is carried out responsibly.

A notable achievement this year has been the publication of a new leaflet. Important changes have been made to the text and new photographs incorporated. It will provide the basis of a publicity drive which we hope will result in an increased membership in the coming months and years.

We are active participants in the Ochils Landscape Partnership (OLP), particularly through our membership of the Advisory Group and the Access sub-group and we will endeavour to ensure that the direction taken by the OLP is in accordance with our aims and objectives. Equally, our continued membership of the Local Access Forum (LAF) will ensure that our voice is heard in relation to the many issues addressed by that group

An important task for the committee over the coming year will be to continue our analysis of the strategic direction to be taken by the Friends of the Ochils. An important dimension of this will be to secure agreement on the draft policy statement drawn up by the committee. Such an agreed policy will help to inform the actions undertaken by the Friends of the Ochils; this is particularly important in relation to our participation in bodies such as the OLP and the LAF.

However the year has not just been taken up with committees, forums, partnerships and campaigns. The Ochils are there to be enjoyed and this year's walks, led by Fenwick Worrell and described in a recent Newsletter, have once again served to remind us of why it is so important to protect the Ochils landscape.

I believe that as an organisation we are raising our profile and consequently our effectiveness in getting our voice heard on many issues. I am hugely grateful for the support, encouragement and advice received the past year, not only from the committee but members as well; without that support our impact as an organisation would be diminished. Thankyou!

PURPOSE AND GOVERNANCE

The objects for which Friends of the Ochils was established are identified in the Constitution (last amended November 2006):

a] To promote and conserve the landscape, natural beauty and wildlife of the Ochils, and to protect the historical and social character of the surrounding communities.

b] To encourage consistent implementation of good planning policies appropriate to the other objects of the Association.

c] To support responsible and well behaved public access to the Ochils consistent with the Scottish Outdoor Access Code.

d] To promote appropriate study of and research into relevant fields of interest pertaining to the Ochils and its local communities, and to promote dissemination of the results of such study and research.

Committee members are elected from the membership for a 3-year period at the AGM, or may be co-opted. Nominations are sought through the Newsletter and at the AGM. The Committee members constitute the Trustees with responsibility for governance consistent with Scottish charity law and regulations. Office bearers are elected by the Committee. Policy and strategy are agreed at regular Committee meetings: four were held in 2008-09. Within agreed strategic frameworks, operational discretion is delegated to specific Committee members leading on particular activities.

COMMITTEE (TRUSTEES)

			Year of initial election	*Current period of office*
President Rennie McOwan	Stirling		n/a	n/a
Chair Stuart Dean	Viewfield Muckhart FK14 7JN	01259 781551 spdean@lineone.net	2005	2008-11
Vice Chair, Treasurer, Membership Secretary Dr Nicki Baker	Parkhead Logie Stirling FK9 4LS	01786 833399 nicki.baker@btinternet.com	2005	2008-11
Secretary Dave Prentice	Tibbermore, Perth	01738 583345 dave_prentice@btinternet.com	2002	2008-11
Newsletter Editor Catherine Kilgour	Stirling	07970 821 483 catkilgour@hotmail.com	2007	2007-10
Fenwick Worrell	Glendevon		2007	2007-10
David Scott	Bridge of Allan		2008	2008-11
Julie Ellis	Edinburgh		2007	*Stood down* Oct 2008
Robin Kelsall	Blairlogie			*Stood down Oct 2008*
Bill Starkey	Crook of Devon		2008	*Stood down* 2009

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Our thanks go to Julie Ellis and Bill Starkey, both of whom left the committee in 2009. Thanks also goes to Dave Prentice who relinquished the post of Secretary, but who continues on the committee as the web-site Secretary. David Scott takes over as Secretary.

The committee always welcomes new members, and will be pleased to hear from any member wishing to join. To stand for election at the AGM, potential committee members must be proposed and seconded by other members of the organisation.

MEMBERSHIP REPORT

Membership increased a little in 2008-09, to 182 plus 8 group members. Renewal rates have remained very high. However, we would like to see a significant increase in membership and, having now updated and reprinted the publicity leaflet, we will be making efforts in 2010 to attract more new members.

Membership at 31 August

	2002	**2003**	**2004**	**2005**	**2006**	**2007**	**2008**	**2009**
Honorary Life	-	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Life	13	14	15	15	14	17	17	16
Family	27	25	30	32	34	34	30	32
Individual	44	44	50	57	61	61	56	56
Concession	39	38	40	39	42	42	38	45
(Total personal)*	**(149)**	**(145)**	**(164)**	**(175)**	**(185)**	**(189)**	**(177)**	**(182)**
Community	6	6	7	5	7	7	8	8
Corporate	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-

* Each Family members counts as 2 people.

As agreed at our last AGM, in 2009-10 subscription rates for Concessionary members will rise to £3, while Individual and Family membership remain the same, at £5 and £7.50 respectively.

With a view to attracting more members, the Committee recommends leaving the subscription rates unchanged for one more year.

FINANCE REPORT 2008-2009

The accounting period runs from 1 September to 31 August. The table below shows income and expenditure during the year 2008-09, the year end position and a comparison with the previous financial year. The annual accounts are examined independently, by Dr Brian Jamieson (Logie), and have been approved by him without qualification.

Income exceeded expenditure by £355 in 2008-09. However, the difference is almost identical to the amount spent on landscape campaigning (£352), and a sum of £2,500 had been earmarked for this purpose at the end of 2007-08. A sum of £2,148 therefore remains available for future campaigning work.

Accounts for year 1 September 2008 to 31 August 2009 (1)

	2008-09		2007-08
INCOME			
Subscriptions	831.00	(2)	711.00
Donations	105.00		98.50
Gift Aid	126.06	(3)	-
Bank interest	208.35	(4)	187.50
Other	-		10.00
TOTAL	**1,270.41**		**1007.00**
EXPENDITURE			
On charitable objects			
Landscape campaigning	352.30	(5)	338.64
Publicity: newsletter & annual review	359.97		408.29
Publicity: website	314.38	(6)	-
leaflets	446.98	(7)	-
On administration			
General administration	151.68	(8)	75.46
Other			
TOTAL	**1,625.31**		**822.39**
SURPLUS (DEFICIT) FOR YEAR	**(354.90)**		**184.61**
ADD Balance at 31 August 2008	4873.36		4688.75
BALANCE AT 31 AUGUST 2009	**4,518.46**		**4873.36**
REPRESENTED BY:			
Bank of Scotland current account	415.07		477.14
Standard Life Bank 10-day community account	4,103.39		4396.22
NET ASSETS	**4,518.46**	(9)	**4873.36**

Notes to the accounts

(1) Accounts are prepared on an income and expenditure basis.

(2) The income received for subscriptions included an additional £90 for Group members' subscriptions collected late for the 2007-08 financial year. (Group members' renewal date is April, compared with other members' renewal date of September.)

(3) The date for collecting Gift Aid was changed during 2006-07, so no Gift Aid could be claimed in financial year 2007-08. This has not affected the total amount we are able to claim.

(4) Interest on our deposits in the Standard Life Bank is paid annually in September, so the sum declared for 2008-09 predated the crash in interest rates. Interest will be considerably lower in 2009-10.

(5) The expenditure on campaigning in 2008-09 comprised our contribution to the joint campaign, with Stirling Before Pylons, to print some 20,000 post cards, and get them signed and sent to relevant politicians.

(6) Expenditure in 2008-09 for website services included costs incurred in 2007-08.

(7) The Friends of the Ochils publicity leaflet was updated and reprinted in 2008-09. Stocks should last for several years.

(8) Extra costs in 2008-09 were incurred as a result of having to postpone the AGM from November 2008 to January 2009.

(9) FotO owns a Reflecta Classic slide projector and Sopar projection screen (bought Aug 2000, cost £190). Both are treated as having nil current value.

- No remuneration was paid to any Committee member or any relative of a Committee member.

- Expenses are paid to Committee members only in respect of verifiable costs incurred on behalf of FotO.

Signed:

For and on behalf of the Committee,
Dr Nicki Baker (Treasurer)

Independent examiner,
Dr Brian Jamieson, Blairlogie

1st November 2009